

100 YEAR HISTORY WALK - PETERBOROUGH POLICE STATION



After intense lobbying by the residents of Petersburg a police station was built in Glogau Street (Bridges Street) by Mr John Chapman at a cost of £706. Prior to this the police officer lived at the Petersburg Hotel, and any prisoner was chained up in the hotel's stable and had to sleep and eat with the horses.

The Police Station had been completed by June 1883 although authorities were already expressed concern that was it is the wrong place, being too far out of the centre of population. The officers were inconvenienced by having to drag their prisoners up a steep hill to the cells behind the station.

At the sitting of the Police Court on Wednesday 5th March 1890, it was mentioned that the present accommodation at the local police house was inadequate. The dwelling itself was unsuitable and the proximity of the cells to be highly demoralizing. The cries and bad language of the prisoners frequently locked up could be heard throughout the house, much to the annoyance of the occupants.

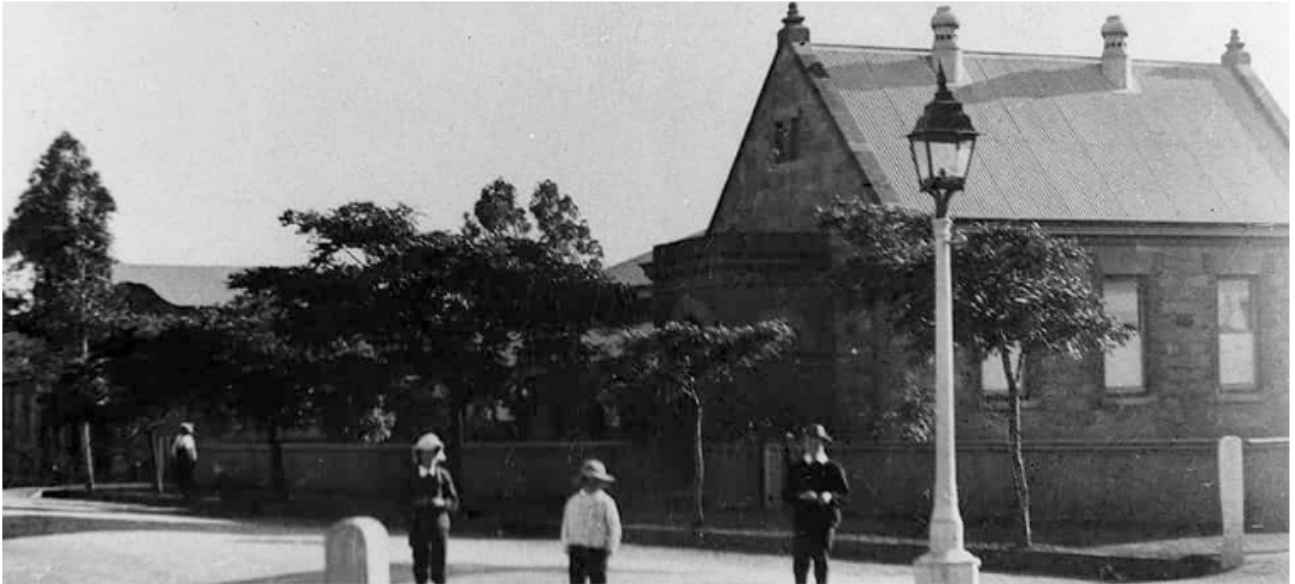
The Commissioner of Crown Lands the Hon W. Copley visited Petersburg on Friday 26th June 1891, and members of the Town Council escorted him through the town. They drew his attention to several local matters that needed attention, an improved railway station or a new one on the town side of the railway line, new police station, and more school accommodation were foremost on the list.

More lobbying to parliament saw money allocated for a new police station late in 1891, but by June 1892 the government had not yet started the process of erecting a new station and courthouse closer to the township. Finally, by the end of the year Messrs Tuck Brothers had construction well in hand. The building was built on the west side of Jervois Street on land purchased from the National Bank by the government. The accommodation included a courthouse, magistrate and strong rooms, residence for the officer in charge, charge room, single men's quarters, cells, and stables.

The new central courthouse and police station was completed by May 1893 and was a decided improvement for the town although it was not yet in use. After a wait of over six months the Petersburg Court House had finally been furnished and was at last operational in December 1893.

It was found that additional cells were needed at the new station as often there was an oversupply of temporary occupants. Only two small cells had been built to hold as many as 10 to 12 prisoners. The local force was considerably undermanned and charges such as drunkenness had seen close to 100 convictions in the first few months.

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*Courthouse and police station – c. 1900
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection*

In 1926 a new police station was erected in Peterborough next to the station built in 1892. The old station was added to the accommodation for the officer-in-charge becoming part of the dwelling.

A new station was built and extra cells were provided. Additional improvements were made to make the station and residence up-to-date and fill a long want in the community.

In the late 1990s the station was again remodelled, and the residence is now part of the station, with officers accommodated elsewhere in the town.



*Police Station – 1974
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection*



Courthouse - 1974
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection



Police Station and Courthouse - 2026
Photo – Janet Fielding

